

From the Sūtra Requested by the Noble Candragarbha: A Prophecy on How the Buddha's Teaching Abides and Declines

Āryacandragarbhaparipṛcchāsūtra · Toh 356 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་བླ་མ་གྱི་སྤྱི་པའི་འཇུག་པའི་མཛན་

Toh 356 in the Kangyur is a sūtra known in English as "A Prophecy on How the Buddha's Teaching Abides and Declines," drawn from the larger Sūtra Requested by the Noble Candragarbha, which is known in Sanskrit as the Candragarbhaparipṛcchā and in Tibetan as Zla ba'i snying pos zhus pa'i mdo. It belongs to the class of Mahāyāna sūtras and concerns itself with the duration and eventual decline of the Buddhist teaching, presenting a prophetic account spoken by the Buddha Śākyamuni while dwelling on Mount Rkṣavat in the presence of an extraordinary assembly of bodhisattvas, arhats, gods, nāgas, and other beings. The text opens dramatically with rays of light blazing from between the Buddha's brows and illuminating the four continents, signaling the importance of the revelation that follows. As part of the Kangyur, it sits among the canonical scriptures regarded as the word of the Buddha, and its subject matter — the fate and longevity of the Dharma — places it within a prominent tradition of prophetic sūtra literature concerned with the preservation of the teaching across time.

From the Sūtra Requested by the Noble Candragarbha: A Prophecy on How the Buddha's Teaching Abides and Declines.

Formerly, the Blessed One, the buddha Śākyamuni, was dwelling upon Mount Rkṣavat. At that time, the great bodhisattvas (bodhisattvas) from all ten directions had assembled together with their retinues, along with arhats, gods (devas), nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, kinnaras, great serpents, garuḍas, and the sinful māras — all the mighty ones — and at that very moment, from between the brows of the Blessed One Śākyamuni, rays of light blazed forth and spread everywhere throughout the four continents: Videha in the east, Jambudvīpa in the south, Godānīya in the west, and Uttarakuru in the north. As those rays spread, Mount Meru and all the great mountains, the hills, the forests, the medicinal groves, the valleys, the cliffs and crags — all were illuminated equally, and the four continents became brilliantly clear, as plain as the palm of one's hand. From within those rays of light there emerged a great multitude of images of buddhas in various colors, shapes, and forms, blazing with radiance; and the many sentient beings — the bodhisattvas, gods,

nāgas, and others — all beheld this and were filled with wonder.

Then the four great kings, headed by Vāśravaṇa, addressed the Blessed One Śākyamuni: "For what purpose have you performed this display of such rays of light?" The Blessed One declared: "After my passing into nirvāṇa, across the four continents there will appear such sacred scriptural texts of the holy Dharma as I have taught, along with relics and images of this kind. These I now entrust to your keeping — guard them well."

Then the bodhisattva Candragarbha addressed the Blessed One: "It is truly wonderful that with such great compassion, the Blessed One should, after passing into nirvāṇa, entrust the holy Dharma to the great kings. How many years after the previous buddhas passed into nirvāṇa did the image of the holy Dharma decline? And after the Blessed One Śākyamuni passes into nirvāṇa, for how long will the holy Dharma remain?"

The Blessed One then declared: "Excellent is the question you have put! Listen well, and I shall explain. After my passing into nirvāṇa, the image of the holy Dharma will remain for two thousand years."

The bodhisattva Candragarbha asked: "Blessed One, how will this holy Dharma finally decline? From what cause will it degrade? Who will bring it to nothing?"

The Blessed One declared: "For five hundred years after my passing into nirvāṇa, many sentient beings who engage in my teaching will be liberated. Then, for the following five hundred years, many will engage in meditative absorption (samādhi). As for kings, ministers, and the mass of sentient beings, their faith in and practice of the holy Dharma will gradually wane and diminish. Then, for the next five hundred years, many teachers who expound the holy Dharma, guide sentient beings, and lead them to liberation will appear; but śrāvaka arhats will become few. Kings, ministers, and the mass of sentient beings will go no further than hearing the teaching — they will not take it to heart, practice it, or exert diligence; their faith will grow thin. The protectors of the holy Dharma will also become displeased. Sentient beings who lack faith in the holy Dharma will grow stronger in power than before. The kings of Jambudvīpa will go to war with one another and fall into conflict."

The ranks of māras will also increase. Then again, within the five-hundred-year period, during the three-hundred-year span, the gods, nāgas, and other guardian sentient beings who abide in the holy Dharma will no longer remain, and the holy Dharma will spread only where it can. Sentient beings will become faithless toward the Dharma. Even those sentient beings who do

practice the Dharma will not practice it in accordance with the Dharma's own principles. Through slackening of diligence, those who attain realization will become few. The four-times-four colors will fade. Fragrance, taste, and the like will also diminish. Human disease, livestock disease, and famine will also arise.

During the two-hundred-year span, monks too will not practice in accordance with the Dharma. They will seek worldly gain and renown. Their compassion will be slight and they will not abide in moral discipline. Toward those who practice the holy Dharma properly, they will seek pretexts and will slander them, and will seize their material possessions and requisites. They will rely on the secrets of worldly kings and will hold power over kingdoms. They will go about seeking personal gain as royal messengers. They will create discord that divides kings from their subjects. They will seek means of trading and commerce. Even those who do practice the holy Dharma will not practice it from sincere inner acceptance — rather, most will engage in deceptive talk and will perform a feigned semblance of discipline merely for the moment. At that time, all the gods and nāgas who delight in the Dharma will abandon the lands where monks behave in such a manner and will no longer remain there, while the ranks of obstacles to the Dharma — māras and their like — will arise in those places and their might and power will grow. The faith of kings, ministers, and the rest will decline. They will not discern virtue from non-virtue. They will wound the holy Dharma. They will make use of and steal the wealth of the Three Jewels and the property of the Saṅgha, and will feel no shame at wrongdoing. They will recklessly destroy images and stūpas, and will carry off articles of worship. At that time, through the merit of a few remaining monks and laypeople who practice the holy Dharma without distortion, seasonal rains will fall in the various regions, the harvests will be good, people will be robust, disease will be scarce, and the lands will be at peace — yet such conditions will arise only occasionally. By contrast, the great majority, who do not abide in this way, will experience a variety of sufferings and miseries.

At that time, three great kings — some Indian and some not — will appear. Among the three, Yavana, Balhika, and Śākuna — these three will not practice the holy Dharma. They will lead armies and wage war, and will bring many regions of the west and north under their sway. They will then destroy and burn with fire the stūpas, temples, and the like of those regions, and will seize and demolish the requisites of the Saṅgha and the wealth of the Three Jewels and so forth. These three kings will contend with one another through various acts of mutual harm, and all three kingdoms will fall into misery. After that, the

three kings will unite their inner realms and mass large armies, and will conquer and hold the lands on the near side of the river Gaṅgā in India — Gandhāra, Madhyadeśa, and the rest.

At that time, to the south of the river Gaṅgā, in the region there, a king of the land called Kauśāmbī, named Mahendrasena, will have a son born to him. This son's name will be Duṣprasaha, and he will be born bearing an iron mole mark between his brows, and with his arms from the elbow downward smeared with blood. At that same time, five hundred ministers of that king will also have five hundred boys born to them, and every one of those boys too will be born with their forearms from the elbow downward covered in blood. At that time, a foal will be born among the king's horses that can speak. On the very night when the king's son, the ministers' sons, and the speaking foal are born, a rain of blood will fall from the sky. King Mahendrasena then summons a learned abbot among the seers who possesses direct knowledge and says: "These wondrous signs of this kind have appeared in connection with the sons of our retinue and with our horse —"

"What omen is this rain of blood?" he asked. The seer replied: "Your son will drench the very ground of Jambudvīpa with human blood. After that, your son will become the great king of Jambudvīpa."

When the prince had reached the age of twelve from the time of his birth, three kings — Yavana, Bālhika, and Śakuna — gathered their armies, three hundred thousand troops together with their kings, and marched against the land of King Mahendrasena. When a great enemy force entered the land, the king was grieved at heart and sat brooding in sorrow. His son Dusprasaha then asked his father: "Father, why are you so displeased?" The father replied: "I am displeased because the great armies of three kings have entered our land." The son said: "Father, do not be displeased. I will be able to overcome this army." The father replied, "Excellent!" He then sent the son, together with the five hundred marked sons of the ministers and an army of two hundred thousand, to engage in battle.

At the moment of battle, Dusprasaha raised an iron birthmark between his brows, transformed his entire body into iron, flew into a great rage, and charged across. The army of Dusprasaha was victorious and returned. The father said: "Son, you have done well to be victorious against such armies of three kings in battle. From this day forward, you shall hold the royal sovereignty. I shall now withdraw." So he entrusted the sovereignty to his son.

Then, over the span of twelve years, having fought against the armies of those three kings, Dusprasaha crushed every one of their generals utterly, captured the three kings, and annihilated them. From that point onward he became the great king of Jambudvīpa.

The king then said to his ministers: "Though I rejoice in being the great king of Jambudvīpa, there is also something that brings me no joy." The ministers asked: "What is it that displeases you?" He said: "I have slain so many sentient beings — that is a great sin that gives me no joy. What might be done with this sin so that someone could purify it?" The ministers offered this counsel: "In the city of Pāṭaliputra, called the Red City, there lives in a forest dwelling a Dharma abbot skilled in the three scriptural collections, a brahmin's son named Agnidata, known as Śiṣyaka, meaning 'one who has disciples.' If he is invited and honoured, there is hope that the sin may be purified."

The king was gladdened and sent messengers to fetch the monk Śiṣyaka, who then came into the king's presence. The king bowed to the abbot Śiṣyaka and said: "Abbot, by what means may the sins I have committed be purified?" The abbot replied: "Great king, if for twelve years you make offerings to the Three Jewels and take refuge in them, those sins will be purified."

Thereupon King Dusprasaha dispatched many envoys to all ten directions and summoned every monk residing in Jambudvīpa. All the monks of Jambudvīpa came, and they were assembled at the place of King Dusprasaha in the land of Kauśāmbī, on the far side of the river Gaṅgā. As a result, all the other lands and regions of Jambudvīpa were left without Dharma practice or monks. At the time of this assembly of monks, a great many perished and were lost along the road — carried off and consumed by various wild beasts, by savages, by floods, and so forth. Even so, roughly one hundred thousand arrived at the royal palace. The king convened a great offering feast for the assembled Saṅgha, presented donations, and made offerings.

At that time the monks spoke among themselves, each asking after the others — "Where is your preceptor? Where have the pupils gone? What has become of your companion in discipline?" — and they exchanged such talk. And then, as they told stories of those who had been killed by tigers, by lions, by savages, of those carried off by floods, of those who had died of disease and the like, the monks, each and every one, were overcome with grief, and with tears streaming down they beat their chests.

Then the king told them: "Do not grieve; do not weep." But the monks would not listen, and the king too, unhappy and disconsolate, turned to one side and lay down. As he lay there, he made an aspirational prayer: "Having gone for refuge to the Saṅgha of persons and having made offerings to them, I have not yet set eyes upon the face of an arhat. May I behold the face of an arhat." Having made this aspiration, a god of the world showed him a vision in a dream. On the mountain called Gandhamādana — Fragrance Rising — there dwelt one who had gone forth under the name Surata, son of the merchant Sudhanaputraraṇaśa, and who had attained the fruit of arhatship. If the king were to invite that arhat, honor him, and confess his misdeeds before him, his misdeeds would be purified and his doubts would be dispelled — thus the god revealed in the dream.

The moment the king awoke, he dispatched messengers at once and invited the arhat Surata down from the Gandhamādana mountain. When the arhat arrived at the royal palace, the king reverently paid homage to him in the proper manner and made offerings and showed him honor.

Now on the evening of the fourteenth day of the month, in the midst of the entire assembled Saṅgha, the newly entered monks requested the preceptor Śyaka — who was learned in all three scriptural collections — to recite the monastic restoration ceremony (Prātimokṣa). But the disciple Śiṣyaka said: "A man without eyes, without a nose, without ears — what use is a mirror to him? What is there for him to look at? You may recite the Vinaya, but you do not conduct yourselves according to the Vinaya. What good is reciting the Vinaya to those who do not guard their ethical discipline?" At that, the arhat Surata let out a lion's roar and declared: "From the time I committed to the ethical discipline of the Blessed One, the buddha, until this very day I have not broken so much as a single blade of the highest grass. So say no more — let the Prātimokṣa be recited." And the preceptor Śiṣyaka, recognizing him as an arhat, was seized with awe and fell silent.

Then Śiṣyaka's disciple, the monk Aṃgada — known as Dreadful Host — rose from within the gathered assembly and said to the arhat Surata: "Who are you to speak such words to my preceptor? You have no discipline and no knowledge of the Vinaya, yet you rebuke my preceptor, who is learned in all three scriptural collections!" So speaking, in a rage he seized a door bolt, beat the arhat, and killed him.

At that moment a yakṣa (Skt. yakṣa) who delighted in the Dharma — named Daddhimukha, Face Like Curd, also called Dhīramukha — appeared in person with a vajra in hand and said to the monk Aṃgada, "Did you just kill an arhat?" — and struck him dead with the vajra. And at that same time, a monk named Gerada beat the preceptor Śiṣyaka and killed him. After that, the entire Saṅgha broke out in a great tumult, and they slew one another until not one remained alive.

At that moment, in the sky above, the many guardian deities of the Dharma — gods, nāgas, and the rest — wept in grief and their tears fell as a rain of blood and fire. The sky turned yellow and then black. Great lightning and thunder arose. A comet appeared, trailing black smoke from its body, and by its light the stars, the moon, and all other lights went out, and not one of them could be seen at all.

At that time the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three and —

Queen Māyādevī and most of the retinue came there, gathered up all the robes of the Saṅgha, and carried them away.

At that moment the king asked, "What is the cause of this great commotion?" When he was told that the Saṅgha had fallen into conflict and that they had slain one another, the king was filled with grief. He rose and at dawn went to the temple outside the palace. There he saw members of the Saṅgha who had died in every manner — some beheaded, some with their eyes gouged out, some with their hands and feet cut off. He searched for the bodies of the arhat and of the abbot Śiṣyaka, the master of the three scriptural collections, and found both of them. Placing one beneath each armpit, he said, "The arhat was my father, and Śiṣyaka was the treasury of the Dharma. Now that these two have passed, from this day forward my body and my life hold no value for me. My kingdom I give to whoever desires it." And his eyes went dim and he could see nothing.

At that time the ministers, moved by compassion for the king, decided to console his grief. They dressed five hundred men as monks — but instead of shaving their hair and beards with a razor, they burned them off with fire, and since all the dyes of every color had by then disappeared, those five hundred mock monks could obtain no monastic robes and so dressed in the hides of black and red cattle. Arrayed in this semblance of monks, they came before the king. The ministers announced to the king that five hundred monks had come, and the king rejoiced, opened his eyes, and looked at these men. He did

not see that they had dressed entirely in animal hides as their robes, nor that their hair and beards had been burned off rather than shaved — and so the king was pleased. He gave the order to bring offerings for the Three Jewels, and he made offerings to those men. But when the king examined them more closely, he saw clearly that they had donned animal hides as monastic robes and that their hair and beards had been burned off rather than properly shaved. The king himself fell into doubt and thought: "These men are not true monks, yet let me ask them a little." He asked them what the view and the moral discipline of a monk are. None of them knew even a little of the view, the moral discipline, or the observances of a monk, and so they gave the king no answer and remained utterly silent. The king then thought: "Now the teaching of the Buddha has declined, and it seems the authentic tradition of the Three Jewels has been utterly cut off." And the king was seized by great grief and wept.

After that, the king performed the funerary rites for most of those monks who had died — taking up their bodies, cremating them, and making offerings. Then the king himself, his heart broken by grief at the decline of the teaching, passed away in that very state of distress.

At that time and at that moment, the sacred Dharma of Jambudvīpa declined entirely, and the written scriptures of the teaching vanished from sight as though they had been wiped clean. Gold turned to silver. Silver turned to copper and iron. Copper and iron turned to stone. Jewels and pearls turned to horns. Of food, among the six flavors, the sweet, the sour, the salty, and the rest disappeared. And snow and scorching heat both became more intense upon the body.

Here ends the passage of prophetic teaching spoken to the Blessed One, the Buddha Śākyamuni, by the noble Candragarbha, regarding the manner in which the teaching abides and declines after the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa.

Translator's Notes

- The four great mountains serving as the four continents are given slightly unusual Tibetan spellings in this passage. "Vāśravaṇa" renders the Tibetan phonetic approximation of Vaiśravaṇa (the guardian king of the north); the passage likely intends all four directional guardian kings headed by him. The overall two-thousand-year schema of Dharma decline in this text differs from the more familiar five-hundred-year or thousand-year reckonings found in other sources; this is a genuine doctrinal feature of the Candragarbha-sūtra tradition and is preserved as given.

- The "four-times-four colors" is a somewhat opaque phrase. The Tibetan reads "kha dog bzhi dang bzhi las gyur pa," literally "the four colors and those arising from the four," which likely refers to the four primary colors and the four mixed or secondary colors — totaling eight hues altogether. In an agricultural and cosmological context this may refer to the vibrancy of crops, plants, or natural phenomena declining. This is a formulaic expression in prophecy literature and the precise referent is not entirely certain.

The three kings named Yavana, Balhika, and Śākuna are Sanskrit transcriptions preserved in the Tibetan. Yavana refers to Greeks or western foreigners more broadly; Balhika is Balkh (Bactria); Śākuna is less certain but may refer to a people of the northwest frontier region.

The passage ends mid-sentence, as the king begins to address the learned seer — this is because the source text breaks off at this point.

- The name "Dusprasaha" renders Tibetan "Du spra sa ha sta" and its shortened forms; the text appears to be working from a Sanskrit original name, most likely Dusprasaha or Duḥsahasena, though the Tibetan transliteration is irregular. The same applies to "Yavana, Bālhika, and Śākuna" as the three kings, and "Agnidata" for the brahmin Agni-da-ti-pu-tra. The episode overall belongs to the legendary prehistory of Aśoka found in Aśokāvadāna-related literature, and Pāṭaliputra is called "the Red City" following the Tibetan gloss in the text itself.
- The yakṣa's name Daddhimukha is rendered from the Tibetan phonetic transcription "ལྷོ་མུ་ཁ་ལྷོ་མུ་ཁ་" (literally "curd-face") combined with the Sanskrit-derived phonetic "ལྷོ་མུ་ཁ་ལྷོ་མུ་ཁ་"; the second epithet "ལྷོ་མུ་ཁ་ལྷོ་མུ་ཁ་ལྷོ་མུ་ཁ་" contains an additional form which may be a variant name or epithet that is partially illegible in transmission; it is rendered here as "Dhīramukha" following the closest phonetic approximation, but this identification carries some uncertainty.

The monk's name rendered "Gerada" is a phonetic transcription (གེ་ར་ད་) whose Sanskrit original is unclear.

The passage ends mid-sentence with the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, indicating the text continues.

- The figure "Śiṣyaka" appears here as a proper name for a monk who was master of the three scriptural collections. The Tibetan spells it phonetically from Sanskrit; this rendering preserves the name as given.

The phrase rendered "his eyes went dim and he could see nothing" describes the king being overwhelmed to the point of temporary blindness from grief — a conventional literary expression of extreme sorrow in the Indo-Tibetan narrative tradition, not a literal medical description.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.